

Jobs in Surveillance: Think First

We, at this university, are here for many reasons, but employment is a big one. Many of us are thinking about our careers and are looking for internships and entry-level jobs. When you get your first job offer, it'll be exciting, but there are of course reasons you may not take that job if offered, or not apply at all. Maybe it doesn't pay enough, it doesn't interest you, or it requires you to move far away. Another reason to reject a job offer could be ethics. We all have our values, and if a company or line of work is at odds with those values, there's good reason to think twice. And an increasingly relevant case of this is surveillance-related work.

Consider these questions. Would you work as a scam caller? Would you take a job making military weapons? Would you work as an ICE agent? I imagine the reader could respond to these questions, though the answer might not be simple, and you might need time to think. That's ok; making decisions about big things like careers are often difficult. But we do need to think about the ethical questions when we consider a job. That includes when that potential work is related to surveillance.

Mass surveillance (large-scale monitoring of people) is a major presence in nearly all our lives. The most evident faces of this are targeted advertisement and social media content recommendations. Full articles could be written about the extent and nature of both of these, but I think most of us recognize some of its presence in our lives. Some time ago – I'm not sure when – it freaked me out when I would get an advertisement on google or amazon for something I recently searched up or bought; now, I don't think much of it, although maybe I should - a topic for another time, perhaps.

And then there's the "algorithms" of social media. Though the term "algorithm" is a simplification of what are usually complicated systems, there are indeed computer processes that automatically recommend or present content to users. You might say sometimes that your "algorithm really knows you". That is because it was designed to know you (and anybody else), or more accurately, know what content will keep you engaged. The patterns we see on social media and advertising are not a result of synchronicity or magic or coincidence, it's the output of machines who know a lot about you.

Sometimes, surveillance is more subtle or behind-the-scenes. Many of our buildings on campus (e.g. dormitories and Belk library) have ID scanners at the entrance. These not only keep unauthorized people out, but it also enables the collection of data about entrants of buildings. And of course, there are cameras around campus. When your attendance is recorded, or you borrow a book from the library, that's surveillance too.

Now, I think many of you would agree that the examples just listed are more benevolent or at least neutral than the first two examples. Indeed, surveillance is not necessarily a bad thing. Sometimes, the same surveillance technology is used for good and bad purposes. [For example](#), NSO Group Technologies' Pegasus spyware has been used to capture El Chapo and bust trafficking rings; but it also was used in the illegal killing of a Washington Post journalist by the Saudi Arabian government and tracking of other political enemies. Ethical responsibility for the use of surveillance technology does not just fall on the user of said technology, but also developers.

Let's talk about AI. Now, AI is often, but not always, classifiable as surveillance technology. These systems require large amounts of training data, and that may very well include information about people. Consider the targeted advertising and social media algorithms

mentioned before. With a growing AI job market, it is increasingly relevant to consider how AI is surveillance technology.

As I wrote, not all surveillance is bad. When you look at a job opportunity where you would be helping develop surveillance technology, I encourage you to think about the work you'll be doing, and what might come of that work. Does any of that go against your values? And you don't need to guess about what you'll be doing. Ask the employer about anything that concerns you.

For some of you, it's hard to imagine finding yourself working on surveillance technology. For others, you might. Those studying Computer Science, Computer Information Systems, Engineering, Marketing, Political and Social Science, Criminal Justice Studies, and those involved with or considering military work, and others may have the opportunity to work on or with surveillance technology.

Now, does the responsibility really fall on us? Aren't there people who manage the ethics of this technology? Well, sort of, but they're not doing a great job. There are the so-called "ethics managers" who manage ethics internally at big tech companies, but [a case study](#) of this found that internal ethics usually serve to "uphold and affirm" business practices. What about professional organizations like the ACM or independent research groups like AINow? These groups do condemn practices they disagree with. The [ACM code of ethics](#) commands that as little personal information be collected as possible, and that it must be obtained and used with consent. In [AINow's 2025 landscape report](#), AINow condemns specific cases of the use of AI and other surveillance technologies. But these are just statements; these groups don't have direct power, nor much power at all, over companies. And the U.S. government? Well, it's often the

government that's funding surveillance development. For example, last year, the Department of Defense [proudly shared](#) that \$200 million contracts were given to big AI companies.

Ethical problems in the real world are often complicated. I recognize that you may not have the luxury of rejecting a job because of your values; we've all got to make our living somehow. But as college students, I think many of us are fortunate to have some freedom with choice of employment. So, let's use that freedom.

Through our effort in college, we earn things. Not just a degree. We earn opportunities – opportunities for knowledge, money, and careers. But we also earn power. In particular, we earn the power to occupy positions we could not otherwise hold, and make decisions we would otherwise not have the privilege to make. Your education is giving you the keys to many doors. And those doors might not be able to be shut once they're opened. What doors will you open?